



Philosophy 101: Ethical Frameworks in Practice — A Full Applied-Ethics Session

Philosophy 101: Ethics • Philosophy

COURSE-OBJ.PHIL101.2

Apply utilitarian and deontological reasoning accurately to real cases, and identify precisely where the two frameworks agree or genuinely conflict. A complete 90-minute session packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner/lab work, independent practice, extension work, assessment, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the session

Course and objective

Philosophy 101: Ethics · Philosophy; COURSE-OBJ.PHIL101.2 — Apply utilitarian and deontological ethical frameworks to the same original case, and evaluate where the two frameworks agree and where they genuinely conflict.

What is included

Cover; instructor guide; key-term and concept preview; original reading or worked examples; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner/lab discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group extension work (4 items); assessment; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (90-minute session)

Warm-up 8 min · read both case files + vocabulary 15 min · guided framework-comparison organizer 18 min · partner position discussion 18 min · independent practice 22 min · extension work 5 min · assessment 4 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key, or distribute through a secure LMS. Review the reading/examples and organizer before class. No paid textbook or app is required.

Student directions

Read or work through the material carefully. Support every answer with evidence, work shown, or clear reasoning.



Before you begin

Key terms

utilitarianism — judging actions by total aggregate consequences

deontology — judging actions by adherence to duty or rule

aggregate harm/benefit — the total summed effect across everyone affected

duty — a moral obligation that holds regardless of outcome

means vs. end — using a person merely as a tool vs. respecting their own goals

consent — a person's voluntary agreement, central to many duty-based objections

Concept focus

Utilitarianism judges an action by its consequences: the right action is the one producing the greatest total well-being (or least total harm) for everyone affected, aggregated across all people. Deontology judges an action by whether it follows a moral duty or rule, regardless of the consequences — some acts (like lying or breaking a promise) are held to be wrong even if they would produce a better outcome. The two frameworks often agree in ordinary cases, but diverge sharply when following a duty would produce a worse aggregate outcome than breaking it, or when maximizing total welfare would require treating one person merely as a means to benefit others.

Model 1 — Applying utilitarian reasoning

A city can spend its budget fixing one dangerous intersection (preventing an estimated 3 serious injuries/year) or repaving five miles of cracked sidewalk (preventing an estimated 12 minor injuries/year spread across more people). A strict utilitarian calculation compares total harm prevented, not just which option "feels" more urgent.

Model 2 — Applying deontological reasoning

A doctor could save five patients by secretly harvesting organs from one healthy, unwilling visitor. A deontologist rejects this regardless of the favorable 5-vs-1 outcome, because it requires using a person as a mere means (without consent) and violates a duty not to kill — the outcome does not justify the rule violation.

WARM-UP

Warm-up

Answer using what you already know or recall from the previous session.

1. Define utilitarianism using the lesson's own wording.

2. Define deontology using the lesson's own wording.



Case File 1: The Whistleblower's Dilemma

Amara works in quality control at a mid-sized auto-parts manufacturer. She discovers that a batch of brake components, already shipped to three dealerships, has a small but real defect rate — internal testing suggests about 1 in 4,000 units could fail under specific cold-weather conditions, potentially causing a crash. Amara's manager tells her the company has signed a strict non-disclosure agreement with the dealerships covering exactly this kind of internal testing data, and that going public would violate a legally binding promise, trigger a lawsuit that could bankrupt the company, and cost around 400 people their jobs — while a voluntary recall handled quietly, dealership by dealership, would fix the actual defect just as effectively without public disclosure.

Amara has to decide whether to honor the non-disclosure agreement and trust the quiet recall process, or break her promise and go public immediately, on the theory that customers have a right to know about a safety risk regardless of the company's preferred process. She has no way to be completely certain the quiet recall will reach every affected vehicle before cold weather arrives.



Case File 2: Two Students Analyze the Dilemma

Two philosophy students, Priya and Julian, are asked to analyze Amara's dilemma using the two frameworks from class.

Priya applies utilitarian reasoning first: she estimates the total expected harm from staying quiet (a small chance of injury per defective unit, multiplied across thousands of units, factored against the quiet recall's effectiveness) against the total expected harm from going public immediately (400 job losses, a company bankruptcy affecting suppliers and their families, but faster and more certain awareness of the risk). Her tentative conclusion: if the quiet recall is genuinely reliable and fast, the aggregate expected harm from staying quiet and trusting the recall could be lower than the aggregate harm from an immediate public disclosure that bankrupts the company — but she notes this conclusion depends heavily on how reliable the quiet recall actually turns out to be, which Amara cannot fully verify in advance.

Julian applies deontological reasoning: regardless of the aggregate outcome calculation, he argues Amara has a duty not to conceal a known safety risk from people who could be physically harmed by it, and that this duty does not bend based on how the numbers happen to work out. For Julian, the non-disclosure agreement cannot override a more fundamental duty to prevent foreseeable harm to third parties who never consented to that agreement in the first place — the dealerships signed it, not the customers who might be injured.

Priya and Julian agree on one thing: Amara should not simply do nothing and hope for the best. But they reach that shared conclusion by fundamentally different reasoning paths.



Partner / lab discussion

Discuss each item with a partner or lab group before writing a joint response.

1. With a partner, identify what specific new information would need to change for Priya's utilitarian conclusion to flip toward favoring immediate public disclosure.

2. With a partner, discuss: does Julian's deontological argument depend at all on how reliable the quiet recall turns out to be? Why or why not?

3. Discuss: is the non-disclosure agreement itself a "duty" in Julian's framework? Explain why or why not, using his own reasoning.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

1. Apply utilitarian reasoning to Model 1 (the city budget case): which project should the city choose, using only the numbers given, and show your comparison.

2. Explain why the lesson's Model 1 warns against choosing based on which option "feels more urgent."

3. Design an original short ethical dilemma (not from this lesson) where utilitarian and deontological reasoning would likely reach different conclusions. Briefly explain why they diverge.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

4. Using your dilemma from the previous question, write one sentence of utilitarian reasoning and one sentence of deontological reasoning about it.

5. A classmate claims "utilitarianism just means doing whatever benefits the most people, no matter what." Identify what is oversimplified about this claim, using the lesson's definition.

6. A classmate claims "deontology just means always telling the truth and always keeping promises, no exceptions." Identify what is oversimplified about this claim, using Julian's reasoning as evidence against it.



Small-group extension work

Use for review or additional application practice.

1. Explain why the dealerships' agreement (not the customers') matters to Julian's argument specifically, using the concept of consent.

2. Write a short paragraph (4-5 sentences) giving your own reasoned position on what Amara should do, using at least one utilitarian and one deontological consideration explicitly.



Small-group extension work

Use for learners ready for additional challenge or synthesis.

1. Explain one genuine strength and one genuine limitation of utilitarianism as an ethical framework, based on what this lesson's cases reveal.

2. Explain why Amara's uncertainty about the recall's reliability makes her decision harder under utilitarianism specifically, compared to under deontology.



Assessment

Complete independently to show what you learned today.

1. Self-assessment: which framework do you find yourself naturally reasoning with more often in everyday life, and can you identify one specific decision (real or hypothetical) where you used it?



Assessment · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this before the next session.



Answer key

1. Utilitarianism judges an action by its consequences: the right action is the one producing the greatest total well-being (or least total harm) for everyone affected, aggregated across all people.
2. Deontology judges an action by whether it follows a moral duty or rule, regardless of the consequences; some acts are held to be wrong even if they would produce a better outcome.
3. Because it requires using a person as a mere means without their consent and violates a duty not to kill, which a deontologist holds is wrong regardless of the favorable numerical outcome.
4. Priya compares the total expected harm of staying quiet (small injury risk across many units, reduced by a reliable recall) against going public (job losses, bankruptcy, supplier harm); her tentative conclusion that staying quiet could produce less aggregate harm depends heavily on how reliable the quiet recall actually turns out to be.
5. Julian argues Amara has a duty not to conceal a known safety risk from people who could be harmed, and that this duty does not depend on the aggregate outcome calculation; the non-disclosure agreement, signed by the dealerships and not the customers, cannot override that duty.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. They both agree Amara should not do nothing and hope for the best; they still count as using different frameworks because they reach that shared conclusion through different reasoning (aggregate-outcome calculation vs. duty-based reasoning), and their frameworks could have pointed in different directions under different numbers.
7. If the quiet recall's reliability were lower than estimated (more defective units going unrepaired, or the recall being too slow for the coming cold season), the expected harm from staying quiet would rise, which could flip her aggregate calculation toward favoring public disclosure.
8. No — Julian's argument is explicitly framed as duty-based rather than outcome-based; the duty not to conceal a known safety risk applies whether or not the recall turns out to be reliable, which is precisely what distinguishes deontological from utilitarian reasoning.
9. Julian treats it as a weaker or overridden duty rather than the governing one — he argues a more fundamental duty (not concealing foreseeable harm to non-consenting third parties) takes priority, and specifically notes the agreement was signed by dealerships, not by the customers at risk, which weakens its claim on Amara.
10. The sidewalk repaving prevents an estimated 12 minor injuries/year versus the intersection fix preventing 3 serious injuries/year; a strict utilitarian comparing total harm prevented would need to weigh severity, not just count, but using the numbers as a simple count-based estimate, the city should identify which option a rigorous aggregate-harm calculation favors and justify it, rather than choosing based on which "feels" more urgent.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. A dramatic, single-location risk (one dangerous intersection) can feel more urgent than a diffuse, lower-severity risk spread across many people (cracked sidewalks), even if the aggregate harm calculation favors the less dramatic option — utilitarianism requires the actual total-harm comparison, not an intuitive urgency judgment.

12. Answers vary; must present a scenario where following a rule/duty would produce a worse aggregate outcome than breaking it (or vice versa), and correctly explain the source of the divergence.

13. Answers vary; each sentence must correctly reflect its framework's reasoning style (aggregate outcome vs. duty/rule) as applied to the student's own scenario.

14. The lesson's definition specifies weighing total well-being or harm, not simply counting how many people benefit; a small benefit to many people is not automatically preferred over a large benefit or harm-avoidance for fewer people — utilitarianism requires an aggregate calculation, not a headcount.

15. Julian's reasoning shows deontology can involve weighing competing duties (the duty to honor an agreement vs. the duty not to conceal foreseeable harm) rather than mechanically following one absolute rule; deontological reasoning can still be complex and can prioritize among duties, not just follow a single rule unconditionally.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Julian's objection relies partly on consent: the customers who could be physically harmed never agreed to the non-disclosure arrangement, so using their safety as leverage to honor a promise they were never party to is, in his view, a separate ethical problem from simply "breaking a promise."

17. Answers vary; must take a clear position and explicitly incorporate both an outcome-based (utilitarian) consideration and a duty-based (deontological) consideration in the reasoning, even if the final recommendation leans toward one framework.

18. Answers vary; a strength might be that it forces explicit comparison of real consequences rather than relying on intuition; a limitation might be that it can be used to justify serious harm to a minority (as in the organ-harvesting example) if the aggregate numbers favor it, or that it requires uncertain predictions (like recall reliability) that are hard to know in advance.

19. Utilitarian reasoning depends on correctly predicting outcomes, so genuine uncertainty about the recall's reliability directly undermines confidence in the aggregate-harm calculation; deontological reasoning is comparatively less destabilized by this uncertainty, since the duty not to conceal a known risk applies whether or not the recall turns out to work well.

20. Answers vary; must identify one framework and connect it to a specific concrete decision or scenario, however small.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

Extension

Ask for a second method, a counterexample, or a short student-led extension of the concept, with a brief explanation of the choice.

Accommodated seating/504

Follow the individual accommodation plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

Additional support

Pre-teach key vocabulary or notation before class. Model the first guided item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

Multilingual learners

Preview key terms with examples. Allow brief first-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence or solution starters.

Course-level alignment · accessed September 18, 2026

COURSE-OBJ.PHIL101.2 — Apply utilitarian and deontological ethical frameworks to the same original case, and evaluate where the two frameworks agree and where they genuinely conflict. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the course-level goal.

Course-level learning objective written for this packet; no accreditation, transfer credit, or universal course-equivalency is claimed.

Original reading(s)/worked examples, questions, and answer explanations. No textbook or copyrighted course material reproduced.

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